GIRL ON A **ROLL**

With a deluge of releases to her credit, 2025 has been a great year for actor Surveen Chawla

In the past two months, wherever one looked on streaming, there was Surveen Chawla. Here she was as the strong-willed Naina in *Rana Naidu* (Netflix); then as wife of the key accused in the new season of *Criminal Justice* (Jio Hotstar); as an ambitious politician with secrets in the crime thriller *Mandala Murders* (Netflix again); and caught up in an investigation with supernatural elements in *Andhera* (Amazon Prime). The deluge led netizens to declare it is as Surveen's breakthrough year. "That's it for me. I have no more goodies," Chawla says of her prolific spell in 2025. The actress is downplaying the good run she's had, which has seen her draw acclaim, particularly for her performance in *Criminal Justice* and being the saving grace of the otherwise underwhelming *Mandala Murders*. "I am glad it happened, but this 'Oh, you have finally arrived' I find shallow," says Chawla. "When you have had such a profound journey, it feels nice to get amazing feedback." With two decades in the industry, where she's acted her way across television, films (Hindi, Punjabi and South) and now web series, she's aware how fleeting adulation can be. Chawla quit TV after three years to embrace the big screen only to get stereotyped after *Hate Story 2*, this despite having indie films like *Ugly* and *Parched* to her credit. "I was medically depressed," she says. "Self-doubt crept in, and one didn't have the backing of names in the industry."

A supreme realisation came eight years back, bringing a much-needed change in outlook. By detaching herself from the end result, Chawla found her liberation. This self-awareness interestingly coincided with the rise of streaming platforms in India. It gave Chawla's career a new lease of life, beginning with *Sacred Games* followed by Netflix's romcom *Decoupled*. The latter may not have been renewed, but it got Chawla eyeballs. The game changer was *Rana Naidu* and this time even Chawla sensed a shift from audiences and creators. The parts coming her way may not be titular, but she has mastered the art of making the most of what she gets. "The attempt is to add value and elevate it a bit," she says. "I am not insecure. I just want to get better, explore more and just focus on what I am doing right now." ■

—Suhani Singh

PLAYING NOW
Sacred Games and *Decoupled* got Chawla eyeballs, but *Rana Naidu* was the game changer

THE RISE OF STREAMING PLATFORMS IN INDIA GAVE CHAWLA'S CAREER A NEW LEASE OF LIFE

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**